

What else to watch: *Cleopatra* (1917) ■ *Broken Blossoms* (1919) ■ *Sunrise* (1927, pp.30–31) ■ *Metropolis* (1927, pp.32–33) ■ *Modern Times* (1936) ■ *Gone with the Wind* (1939, pp.62–63) ■ *Ben-Hur* (1959)



The central courtyard in Babylon was recreated with a life-size set. More than 3,000 extras were employed for Belshazzar's lavish feast.

To some critics, the effect is almost symphonic, while others find it tiresome. But there is no doubt that this crosscutting and use of the edit was to prove hugely influential.

Other technical innovations we now take for granted include dissolves between scenes and the fade-out. Most significant of all, perhaps, was the close-up. The full-length shots of earlier movies called for an exaggerated, pantomime style of acting to convey the story. But as Griffith said, "The close-up enabled us to reach real acting, restraint, acting that is a duplicate of real life." ■

film tint. They are linked by the ever-present image of a mother, played by Lillian Gish, rocking a cradle to symbolize the passing generations. Captioned "Out of the cradle endlessly rocking," it suggests that nothing changes.

The first of the four stories focuses on the conflict at the fall of ancient Babylon, fueled by the intolerant devotees of two warring religions. The second tells how, after the wedding at Cana, Christ is driven to his death by intolerance. The third tale depicts the St. Bartholomew's Day massacres in France in 1572, when Catholics massacred the Protestant Huguenots. The final story is of two young lovers who are caught up in a conflict between ruthless capitalists and moralistic striking workers. Griffith is clearly on the side of the lovers, who are hounded by the type of social reformers he clearly equates with those who protested against *The Clansman*.

The four stories are intercut with increasing rapidity as the movie approaches its climax. Racing chariots in one story cut into speeding trains and cars in another; this effect was achieved almost entirely in the edit, since Griffith shot the sections chronologically.



Jesus drags his cross through jeering crowds in the movie's biblical story.